

Q: How important is India as a market for SAP? What is the kind of growth you are seeing and what is your future strategy?

A: I would say India is for me, end to end, the most important market because our biggest lab outside of Germany is not in the US, but in India. We have big plans to hire more young talent in India, as we see a great talent base there. I'd ask the Indian government to double down on education, because at the end, it's the people and their skills that will make sure that India will thrive in the future.

The second thing is that India has some 60 million SMEs (the mid-market). That's like almost all the people living in Germany! And the great thing is all of these companies [are] looking at technology to succeed in the market. It's not like we need to convince these companies; now they come and tell us, 'Hey, we want to have SAP helping us to grow our business.'

Last but not least are our partners. Our biggest ecosystem is in India—HCL, TCS, Wipro, Infosys—SAP cannot be successful without our partners in India. They are helping us bring the software to all corners of the world. You have the biggest ecosystem now helping us to develop and implement our software. This is India. And now you also hopefully can understand why I'm spending so much time in India, because it's a very, very important market for us.

Q: What kind of expertise does SAP look for when hiring in India?

A: First, I can only emphasise how important it is to further invest in education. We are hiring from Bengaluru, Mumbai and Delhi. But when I look around, there are also a lot of Tier 2 locations. Our Chairman-designate [Punit Renjen], who knows India really well, said to me, 'Christian, there are [other] places and locations in India we should definitely look into to further expand, because of the talent there.' Compare this with Germany or the US [and] you have an incredibly big talent pool.

What are the future profiles we are looking for? AI specialists, data scientists, cybersecurity and data privacy [experts]. These are profiles you don't find everywhere in the world. We would strongly recommend policies that invest in skilling and education for these profiles.

Having smart people who can talk about digital transformation and making sure you're connecting businesses with technology [is important], because in the end, digital transformation will only happen if you have people who understand an industry and can connect it to technology. Because a piece of technology on its own [has] no value. Getting your landscape to

“During my recent visit to India, the interest was high among all the other CEOs visiting [the country]—from car manufacturers to chemical companies—to invest in India, because the supply chains will change”

the cloud with a hyperscaler will not transform your company; what will transform your company is the software—rather applying the software of SAP to the specific business of our customers. So, this combination of skills and industry knowledge, in combination with technology, is a great skill to have in the future, and is relevant for all of our customers in India as well.

Q: How was your meeting with Prime Minister Narendra Modi earlier this year?

A: I was amazed [at] how much your Prime Minister knew about SAP, about our technology and what we do for India. He had concrete plans and thoughts about how technology can help India thrive around sustainability, commerce, and the supply chain. That was great to see. Your government and your Prime Minister are on top of digitisation, and see technology as a great opportunity for India to drive the economy.

We talked about the digitisation of the railways, green transition, helping some of the energy companies to move to clean energy. We talked about commerce and helping the SMEs, the mid-sized companies in India, to thrive and digitise their sales—and help them expand their business to the world. These were a few concrete topics, and he took out a lot of time to meet us. And I guess all the German CEOs, including me, left the meeting with the impression that India is the place to be, and we definitely want to double down on India.

Look, with all the tensions [that] are going on worldwide, companies are thinking: 'Where do I build my next factory? Where do we invest in our next lab? Where do we invest into our go-to market, into local resources?' And there are a lot of strong arguments to invest in India right now. And that's why I'm very optimistic when it comes to the future of India. **BT**

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